Nehru, Mao Zedong made no mention of India as a major partner to China, and believed China would be the main guarantor of peace in post-war Asia. [4]

After the independence of India in August 1947, the two countries established embassies. However, the rapid advances by Mao's Communist armies inside China in 1948 meant that there was little bilateral interaction between independent India's new government and the Chinese Nationalist government of Chiang Kai-shek. Nehru keenly followed the developments of China's civil war. By September 1948, Indian Ambassador K.M. Panikkar was reporting to New Delhi about the imminent collapse of President Chiang Kai-shek's regime. The Communist General, Lin Biao, had seized the entire north-eastern region of China and Beijing was poised to fall. To the south, General Liu Bocheng had defeated the Nationalist forces in the Battle of Hsuchow (Suzhou) and was threatening the capital in Nanking (Nanjing). Panikkar informed the Government of India on 2 December 1948 that Chiang's government would, hereon, be 'no more than a phantom or fugitive government'. [5]

Nehru's instincts told him that if a Communist victory was inevitable, India's interests would be better served by establishing early contact with them. Panikkar, with the Indian government's acquiescence, began reaching out to the Chinese Communists. On 5 October 1948, Qiao Guanhua, who headed the Hong Kong branch of the New China News Agency (and was to become China's Foreign Minister in the 1970s), sought instructions from the Communist Party Central Committee on an overture by the Counsellor of the Indian Embassy in Nanking to visit the 'liberated areas'. [6] Signalling his desire to maintain ties with the new regime, Nehru also decided that the Indian Ambassador should not withdraw from China even if the Nationalist government were to collapse. [7] A suggestion